

Ancient monuments

Structures made from rock or stone are often all that remain of past civilizations, and can give us insight into the skills, customs, and beliefs of the people who built them. Hundreds of laborers would have been needed to construct each of these massive monuments.

Limestone marvel

Great Sphinx

Where Giza, Egypt

When c. 2500 BCE

The ancient Egyptians built statues of sphinxes—mythical creatures, usually with a human head and lion's body—to guard tombs and temples. Carved from a single block of limestone, the Great Sphinx of Giza is one of the world's largest stone structures.



The head of the Great Sphinx may represent Pharaoh Khafre.

Megalithic tomb

Munbung-ri Dolmen

Where Pyongyang, North Korea

When c. 3300–1200 BCE

This structure made up of large prehistoric stones, or megaliths, is called a dolmen. Erected in the Bronze Age, it was probably the tomb of an important person. The Korean Peninsula contains more than 40,000 such dolmens—40 percent of the total number in the world.



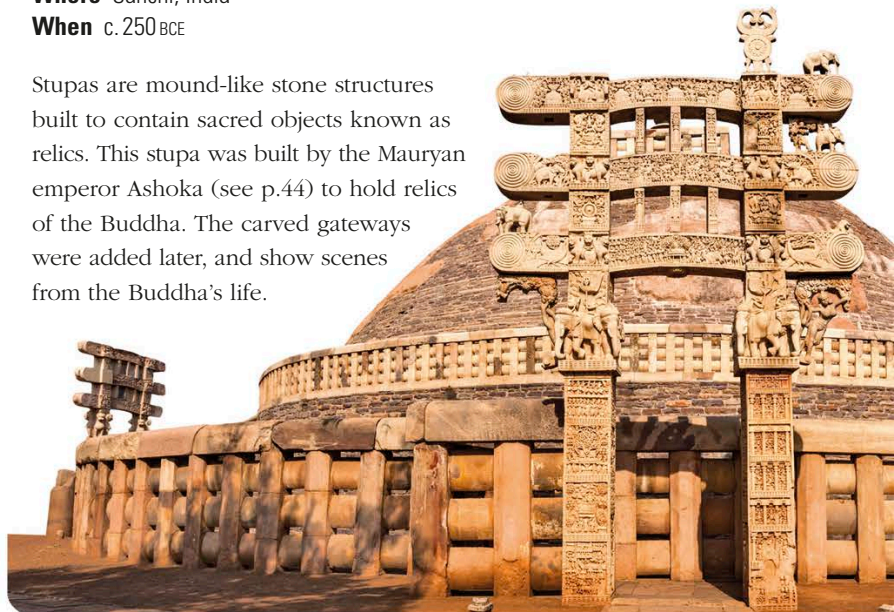
Buddhist shrine

Great Stupa

Where Sanchi, India

When c. 250 BCE

Stupas are mound-like stone structures built to contain sacred objects known as relics. This stupa was built by the Mauryan emperor Ashoka (see p.44) to hold relics of the Buddha. The carved gateways were added later, and show scenes from the Buddha's life.



Roman amphitheater

The Colosseum

Where Rome, Italy

When 80 CE

In Roman times, bloodthirsty shows such as gladiator fights and wild animal hunts were put on in this vast open-air arena. Its four tiers of stone seating could accommodate up to 50,000 spectators.

